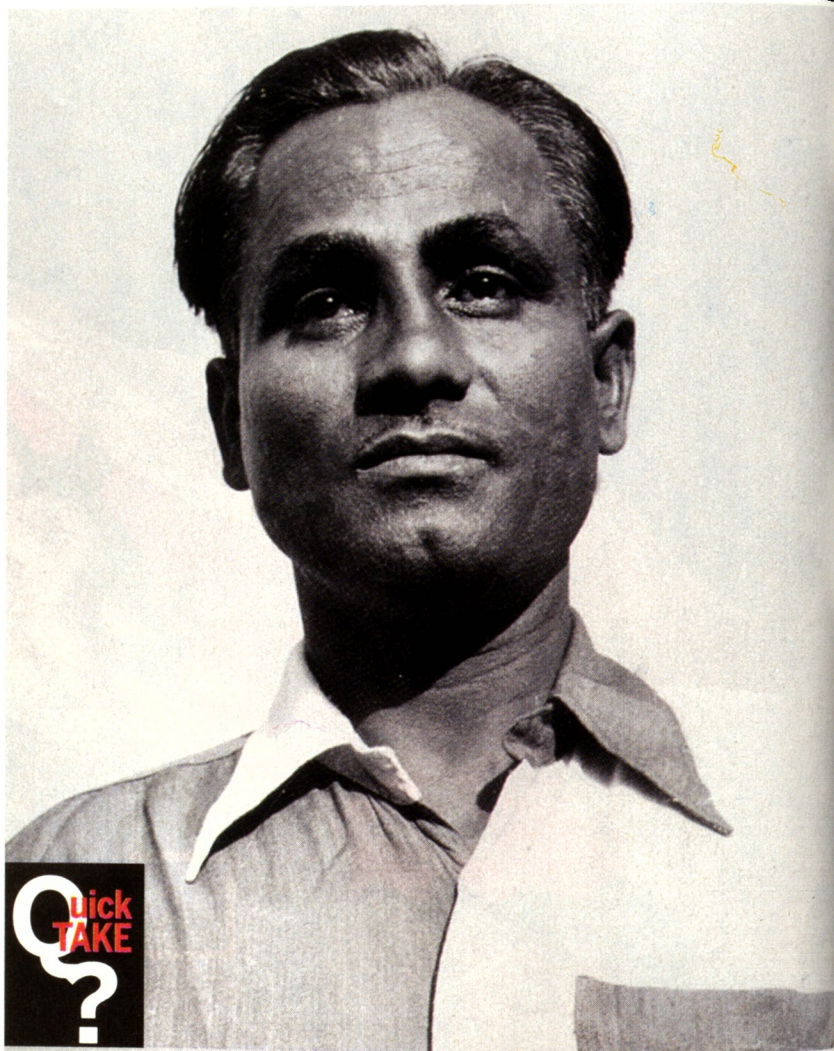


Berlin Olympics came in for a cornucopia of accolades, filling every Olympic historian's work, as his feats were considered challenging, a worthy rebuff to the emerging Nazi tendencies. What about Dhyhan Chand? The 'Non Aryan' had not only scored 20 goals in the previous two Olympics, but a mind boggling number at Berlin too, including three in the final (Olympic records credit him with six out of eight goals that India scored in the final, but in his autobiography *Goal* he claims only three, and this honesty is his greatness) against Germany, pricking their ego in a big way.

The global impact of Dhyhan Chand needs a thorough multi-dimensional research. Equally interesting is how this ordinary Indian, who "could just read and write"—this is how he describes himself in *Goal*—wrote the destiny of global hockey, while also breaking the mental block of those who managed sports in his era.

Only high-profile players were made the team leaders. Jaipal Singh, the 1928 Olympic captain, was not even in India, but was a student at Oxford University when he got this honour. His successor at the 1932 event, Lal Shah Bokhari, could hardly match the calibre of other players in the team which included brothers Roop Singh and Dhyhan Chand and a half dozen others in their second Olympics. But the greenhorn, who would later become Pakistan's High Commissioner in Ceylon, got the nod. That neither Jaipal nor Bokhari played their second Olympics is the case in point. Therefore, when he was made the captain for the Berlin Olympics, Dhyhan Chand considered it a greater moment in his life than when he was selected for the first Olympics.

Dhyhan Chand's legacy is not just confined to the pre-Independence era. It continued. After the "World's Biggest Divorce", to quote from *Freedom at Midnight*, when even furniture in government offices was counted and allocated between the divorcees during the Partition, strong



Q: Where can one find a statue of Dhyhan Chand with four hands and four sticks to signify wizardry?

A: At a sports club in Vienna

Q: His real name was Dhyhan Singh. Where did he pick up Chand?

A: His coach Pankaj Gupta named him
Chand predicting that he would one day shine like the Chand or moon

Q: How is his birthday, August 29, celebrated in India?

A: As National Sports Day

Q: What other sport did he love?

A: Billiards

Q: After watching him play, who told him, "You score goals like runs in cricket"?

A: Sir Donald Bradman

claims were made to declare India's three Olympic golds neutral, like British India or Undivided India. They had a strong case. The 1936 Berlin Olympic Indian team of 18, for instance, had eight Anglo Indians, four Muslims and two Hindus from Pakistan. But free India won that psychological war as all of those 14 souls dwarfed against the towering dinosaur, Dhyhan Chand.

And this man, oblivious of his significance, claims in *Goal*: "I realise that I am not a very important man, good enough to write an autobiography." Will such a soul ever cease to radiate or fail to illuminate Indian nationhood?

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